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The Woman in Trousers: Marlene Dietrich and the Fabric of Her Studio System Stardom

Marlene Dietrich was never truly the star that Hollywood wanted but, rather, the one it needed. Her career was shaped by early studio relationships and most importantly, her desire to rewrite expectations. She was first discovered in Germany by director Josef von Sternberg, who would cast her as Lola-Lola in *The Blue Angel* (1930). After achieving international praise for the performance, she signed a seven-year contract with Paramount Pictures and Sternberg in particular, where they would go on to construct an unforgettable star persona through films like *Morocco* (1930) and *Shanghai Express* (1932). Initially presented by Paramount as the perfect fatale to rival MGM's Greta Garbo, Marlene Dietrich's convention-breaking nature would later outline the tension between studio control and star agency. In 1938, after the Paramount contract ended, she was labelled "box-office poison" and continuously voiced her opposition to Nazism, shifting her career towards defiance. Regardless, she would continue to work in Hollywood for decades and construct a complex stardom blending her studio-manufactured mystique with her real-life non-conformance and androgyny. By analyzing representations of Dietrich's career in modern-age media, the careful curation and evolution of her gleaming reveals itself.



Fig 1: Photoplay, April 1931



Fig. 2: Photoplay, May 1931



Fig 3: Photoplay, January 1933



Fig 4: Movie Classic, August 1935

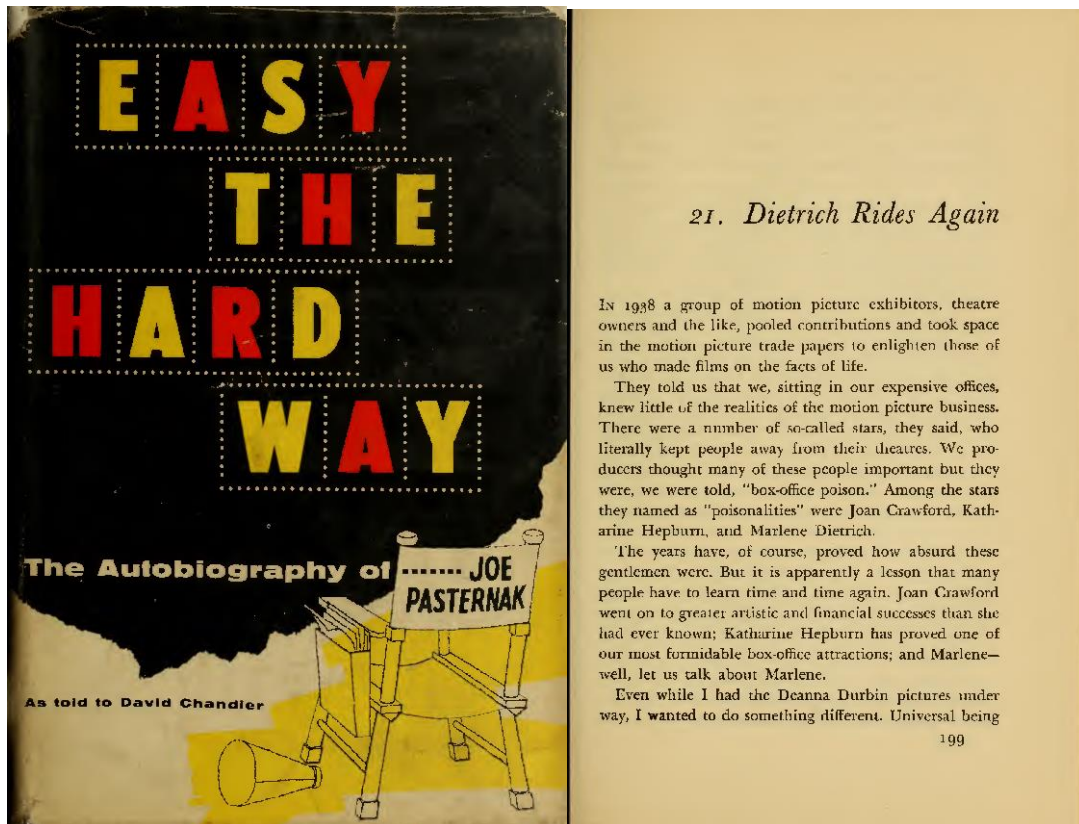


Fig 5: Easy Hard Way by Joe Pasternak, 1956

Fig 1. Photoplay, April 1931: "Dietrich, How She Happened"

Released near the beginning of her American reception, the *Photoplay* April 1931 article "The Perils of Marlene" dissects Marlene Dietrich's image, which rejects the typical American beauty expectations. Contrasting European and American women, the piece suggests that while Dietrich's German origin makes her an "incomplete" woman, it allows her to assert sex appeal more powerfully than a typical American star. Therefore, her ability to embody the roles of "wife, mother, and sweetheart simultaneously" is formed through an interplay between these constructions of European mysteriousness and true American femininity. This article sets the

basis for understanding how Dietrich's unique mix of identities helped form a fresh face of multi-faceted stardom.

Fig 2. Photoplay, May 1931: "The Perils of Marlene"

Just a month later came the Photoplay article, "The Perils of Marlene." Diving deeper into her image, it examines the tensions between Marlene Dietrich's roles as a sex symbol and as a potentially serious actress. Referred to as a "hot box-office pet," the article attributes her American popularity to her physical allure, specifically her legs. Described in fetish-like detail, her legs become a star of their own. While her charms are also noted, the article criticizes and over-focus on sensuality, implying that until she can deliver a performance that transcends her sex symbol status, she cannot be called a real artist. An important complexity arises from this, one that highlights the struggle between a woman star's sexual expression and her desire for recognition beyond physicality—the battle of being desirable without being too desirable. This fight between audience indecision and reception is one that would persist for the rest of her career.

Fig 3. Photoplay, January 1933: "Is Dietrich Through?"

Released in 1933, "Is Dietrich Through" details an interview after a period of uncertainty in Dietrich's career. Spending seven months off-the-radar following a kidnapping threat against her daughter, there are questions regarding the future of her Hollywood career, especially with the upcoming expiration of her Paramount contract. Despite her popularity, Dietrich expresses her lack of enthusiasm for filmmaking, admitting a plan to retire after *Blonde Venus*, only ever wanting to work with Sternberg. This article unlocks the psychological aspects of her

physicality-focused persona. Luckily, these retirement plans didn't reign true. Dietrich also showed up to the interview in "manly attire" (yet another subversion of feminine conventions), but it's noted that regardless of the clothes she wears, she retains an unmistakable femininity. This period marks an important shift in her image from glamour to introspection, encouraging audiences to look deeper while also emphasizing fluid gender expression.

Fig. 4. *Movie Classic*, August 1935: "Not the Best Dressed, But the Most Important"

The *Movie Classic* 1935 article "Not the Best Dressed, But the Most Important" explores Dietrich's power as a fashion influence, showcasing her trendsetting capabilities in Hollywood. While not always being considered the "best dressed," the article emphasizes her ability to make daring, bold fashion choices which could only really be pulled off by someone with her persona. Her designer, Travis Banton, also explains her popularization of the "modified masculine look," which existed before but was finally made desirable by Dietrich. Importantly, this article marks a landmark in her star persona as a figure who resonates not only with men as an object of desire but with women as a source of empowerment through androgynous femininity. Unlike many of her counterparts, Marlene Dietrich became a symbol of sensuality, power, and a refined sense of gender expression.

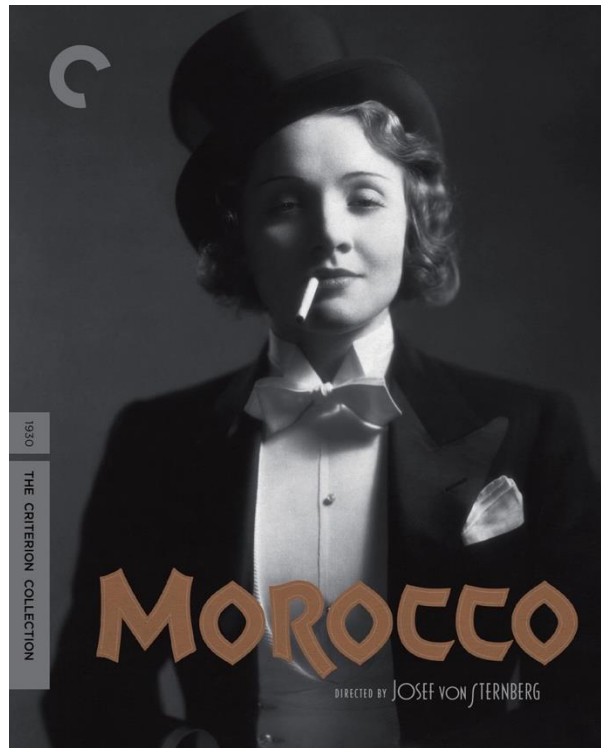
Fig. 5. *Easy the Hard Way* by Joe Pasternak, 1956: "Dietrich Rides Again"

In Joe Pasternak's autobiography, *Easy the Hard Way*, written 20 years after Dietrich's American debut, he reflects on the progression and low points of her career through the perspective of a producer who worked with her. After her partnership with Sternberg ended and she dedicated her time to American war efforts, her popularity had significantly waned.

Pasternak offers an intimate account of her reality as a grounded figure, a transition from the image of glamorous ‘seductress’. While her public image was meticulously crafted by studio powers, he describes her true self, of kindness and selflessness, as the true source of her star power. Revealing her efforts to help victims of the Nazi regime, this piece captures a shift from Dietrich as a foreign allure to a resilient woman with an unknown depth. By the 1950s, her appeal was no longer based on sexuality but on strength and independence.

Article Analysis

In sum, these articles trace the nuanced evolution of Marlene Dietrich’s persona, the combination of self and star. In the early 1930s, the ideas of European “exoticism” and sexual allure ruled her image, but just a few years later, her trailblazing was showcased through her androgynous style and influence on fashion, curating a fanbase of both men and women. By the 50s, she further evolved from her initial objectifying image, being known as a woman of character and independence. Blending key elements such as a rejection of traditional labels, a fusion of American and European identities, and the transcension of gender norms shaped the star persona we know today. From “hot-box-office pet” to “box office poison” to a timeless icon of resistance, the adaptation of Dietrich’s image secured her long-standing place in Hollywood as a truly complex figure. Arguably, the only aspect more formative than fan magazines in her star identity were the roles she starred in.

Birth of a Star: *Morocco* (1930)

Marlene Dietrich dressed in a tuxedo for *Morocco* (1930)

Josef von Sternberg's *Morocco* (1930) builds the foundation of Marlene Dietrich's star career, representing her as both sexually alluring and boundary-pushing. As Amy Jolly, a magnetic cabaret singer caught between a Foreign Legion soldier (Gary Cooper) and a wealthy playboy (Adolphe Meniou), Dietrich embodies the ethereal passion that became central to her image. This film marks her true introduction to American Audiences, along with her first and only Academy Award nomination, which helped cement her stardom.

Morocco reinforces Dietrich's curated persona through its visual style and narrative elements. Under Sternberg's direction, her image is sculpted with moody star lighting and veils of cigarette smoke that enhance the European mystery. Her performance exudes sensuality but

also remains detached, reinforcing Dietrich as an untouchable, otherworldly figure. However, it is Amy Jolly's shocking act of wearing a tuxedo in a high-society nightclub that highlights a defining trait of Dietrich's persona: androgyny. This paired with a brief but daring on-screen kiss with another woman, greatly contributes to the gender-defying element of her personage.

While *Morocco* initially supported Hollywood and Paramount's desire to mould Dietrich into "the next Garbo," it also hinted at her eventual divergence. Her androgyny, combined with growing independence, foreshadowed her later rejection of typical conventions. Though her early persona thrived on the ambiguity and allure seen time and time again, *Morocco* subtly complicates this by showcasing a woman who was never meant to remain a blank slate. The very same qualities that sensationalized Dietrich in the 1930s, would ultimately lead to Hollywood's struggle to contain her in the way it would've liked to.

***Morocco's* Critic Reception**

The *National Board of Review Magazine's* 1930s review of *Morocco* offers a glimpse into critics' initial perceptions of Marlene Dietrich. While it devotes little space to her mention, what is said is striking. She is described as a "shining new star" with a "distinct personage," that sets her apart from other stars. Her wit and glamour are praised, with only one other star being claimed as comparable. Regardless of being unnamed, this is undoubtedly a reference to Garbo, reinforcing Dietrich's position as a rival figure. This review confirms the persona of an enigmatic, fresh European actress while also representing the industry's attempts at limiting her individuality.

NATIONAL BOARD of REVIEW MAGAZINE



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Marlene Dietrich in "Morocco" (see page 4)

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EXCEPTIONAL PHOTOPLAYS

A department devoted to an impartial criticism of the best photoplays. Each picture is selected and discussed by a committee of the National Board composed of critics, authors and actors of the screen, who are the members of this department. The combined opinions of this Committee are made available to the public in written form. Each review aims to give a comprehensive idea of the picture, showing back its criticism and artistic. Each department seeks to make all photoplays of outstanding merit in the artistic development of the screen and to give it a more intelligent picture to the attention of discriminating readers.

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Morocco

Directed by.....Joseph Von Sternberg
Photographed by.....Lee Gurnea
Play "Amy Jolly" by.....Henri Vigny
The Cast
Legionnaire Von Brown.....Gary Cooper
Amy Jolly.....Marlene Dietrich
La Houlle.....Adolphe Menjou
Produced and distributed by Paramount

MANY discerning commentators have felt, some even from the time of the early silent *Monsters*, that in Joseph Von Sternberg our screen had found its most interesting exponent, an experimentalist whose work would sooner or later parallel in its creative aspect the work of artists in other fields and mediums of expression. Undoubtedly we try to substitute this feeling. It had form, dramatic meaning, aesthetic purpose. It recognized the box-office, but it did not trouble to it. It was a silent film. Then came sound and dialogue. In its effort to reproduce the songs, the dramatic pattern of the motion picture, carefully developed through a span of thirty and more years, slipped back over night to the verge of its creative beginning. What would Mr. Von Sternberg do with the decaying device of the mike, the disk and the sound track.

Mr. Von Sternberg, it would seem, set out to find a proper use for them with a keen determination to preserve the cinematic pattern. The use dialogue and sound as adjuncts and not as principles of fundamental change. After a period of testing in which he produced several worthy sound films, he now comes before us with *Morocco*.

It is our purpose, only to him at its photoplay and the inherent authenticity of its characters. Neither, striving as they undoubtedly are, by themselves make it the outstanding film for, is a deliberate step forward in the art of motion pictures, one of the most noteworthy films, many will think when they have studied it, that the sound screen has yet produced. However, some outline must be understood in order to give the most background to a study of the technical perfection of the production.

To the hot Algerian locale, then, comes a strange, exotic person, a young actress of the trouper's stage, adventuring, her antecedents more than elegantly indicated. Once installed as a singer in the local cabaret, she comes by a great passion for a companion soldier of the Foreign Legion, a company of which happens to be quartered in the town. A wealthy Arab now falls in love with her, offers to marry her. The soldier, having failed in his promise to desert and take her back to Europe, she consents to his marriage. But she is up by following the Legionnaire into the desert, when he marches away the second time with his company, leaving after him with the native women, the camp followers, who cannot give their men up.

Thus, like all motion pictures of the front rank, the material is that of the screen alone, the narrative thread an exceedingly simple one. It amounts to the way it is unfolded. And here the result is that cinematic

National Board of Review Magazine, November 1930

The Fan Magazine and Star Persona

Flipping through a 1930s *Photoplay* issue reveals the complex machinery behind Hollywood's star system and its relationship to fan culture. These magazines construct stardom as equal parts middle-class escapist fantasy and commercial product, with their content balancing manufactured intimacy and overt advertising. By presenting trivial anecdotes and dubious "facts" about stars' lives, they create a false notion of accessibility while maintaining mystique. This approach transforms actors into consumable commodities—Dietrich's legs become adverts for pantyhose while vague celebrity "beauty secrets" promote cosmetics. Sections are devoted to listing studio addresses for fan mail, further illustrating the industrial nature of star-fan relationships. While the overt sexism and commercial transparency are both shocking and

unsurprising to contemporary eyes, these fundamental strategies of celebrity commodification remain remarkably consistent with current star media practices. Magazines ultimately reveal Hollywood's mission to craft compelling fantasies while simultaneously monetizing every aspect of stardom.

Conclusion

Dietrich's most radical disobedience was her redefinition of femininity by challenging Hollywood's idea of gendered glamour. Her trousers and tuxedos transcended fashion, becoming political statements. This was demonstrated by her choice to wear a tailored suit to the premiere of Cecil B. DeMille's scandalous *The Sign of the Cross* (1933). The film's infamous "lesbian dance" sequence (later removed under the Hays Code) was said to be one of the catalysts of code-era Hollywood. This message, paired with rumoured bisexuality and "connection" with Greta Garbo, highlighted the relationship between her off-screen identity and marginalized sexualities. Studios still managed to commercialize her rebellion, marketing her "modified masculine look" while continuing to suppress authentic non-conformity. However, Dietrich's true talent lay in navigating the reality of performing glamour on camera while living unconventionally behind it. Her star significance stems from exposing Hollywood's central contradiction: that long-lasting stardom required both meticulous image-crafting and a genuine subversion of norms.

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